

C. 20. On Ashdod. While Ashdod was besieged by the Assyrian troops in 711, Isaiah walks the street of Jerusalem in a captive's garb, continuing to do so for three years, in order to prefigure the shameful fate that would befall Egypt at the hands of the victorious Assyrians.

The date is fixed by Sargon's inscriptions, which allude to the siege of Ashdod, and imply that the revolt of the Philistines, which led to it, was carried through with promises of help from Egypt. Isaiah's symbolical act was doubtless meant indirectly as a protest against the Egyptianizing party in Jerusalem, and intended to impress forcibly upon the people of the capital the folly of reliance upon Egypt.

21, 1-10. On Babylon. The prophet in imagination sees Babylon besieged by an eager and impetuous foe, *vv.* 1-2: the vision agitates and appals him, *vv.* 3-4: the issue, for a while, appears uncertain, but in the end he is assured that the city has fallen, *vv.* 5-9; and he announces the result as a duty imposed upon him, but with no sense of satisfaction or relief, *v.* 10.

The prophecy has been commonly referred to the capture of Babylon by the Medes and Persians under Cyrus in 538 B.C. This view is open to two objections: (1) no intelligible purpose would be subserved by Isaiah's announcing to the generation of Hezekiah an occurrence lying nearly 200 years in the future, and *having no bearing on contemporary interests*; (2) it does not account for the alarm and aversion with which the prophet contemplates the issue (*vv.* 3, 4, 10), so different from the exultation displayed elsewhere by the prophets when announcing the fall of the great oppressing city (c. 13, 2-14, 23; c. 40-48; Jer. 50-51). The first of these objections would be obviated by the supposition that the prophecy is really the work of an author writing towards the close of the exile (Ew. Hitz. &c.); but even so the second would still retain its force. Hence the prophecy has been referred by Kleinert, *Stud. u. Krit.* 1877, p. 174 ff., Cheyne, and the present writer (*Isaiah*, p. 96 ff.) to a siege of Babylon by the *Assyrians* in Isaiah's own time. The inscriptions show that Merodach-Baladan made repeated efforts, in the time of Sargon and Sennacherib, to free Babylon from the Assyrian yoke, and that the Assyrians on three separate occasions, B.C. 710, 703, and 696, besieged and entered the rebellious city. As Merodach-Baladan had probably (c. 39) some understanding with Hezekiah, the struggle between him and the Assyrians would be watched with interest in Judah: the success of the latter would mean the punishment of those suspected of being implicated with him. This success (perhaps in 710) Isaiah finds it his duty to announce. His human sympathies are with his own people: he foresees the sufferings which the present triumph of Assyria will entail upon them ("my threshing," &c. *v.* 10); and hence the distress with which the prospect fills him (*v.* 3 f.), and the apparent unwillingness with which he delivers his message. This view of the prophecy has not, however, found favour with recent writers on Isaiah (Delitzsch; Kuen. § 43. 10; Dillm.),